

The Tell: Which Pitch-Sequencing Giveaways Survive New Games

Introduction. Advance scouts sell sequencing tells (“after a slider he doubles up”), and clubs act on them. Nothing public separates real tells from patterns found by searching. We ask how much the previous pitch gives away beyond count and batter hand, how much of a scouted tell survives into new games, whether predictability costs pitchers, and whether the 2026 automated ball-strike (ABS) challenge system changed it.

Methods. All 2,049,352 Statcast pitches, 2024–2026 (1,793 pitcher-seasons with 250+ pitches). Nested models predict pitch type from batter hand, then count, then the previous pitch, scored on unseen games. TELL is the previous-pitch gain per pitcher-season, over pitches after a plate appearance’s first. A cue is the count, hand and previous pitch that most shifts one pitch type’s share. Each pitcher’s top cue is found in April–June (or 2025) and scored only on later games, also net of the league-wide shift. Outcome regressions fix pitcher-season, pitch type $\times$ count $\times$ hand, and velocity. An in-season alarm multiplies game-by-game permutation e-values within count and batter hand. ABS effects use paired pitchers, 2024–25 as comparison.

Results.

- Added in that order, hand and count carry 102 and 58 millibits; the previous pitch adds 12.8. Guessing the likeliest pitch, a hitter gains 0.8 points of accuracy, 7 against Dylan Cease.
- Selection inflates tells. The top April–June cue shifts the next-pitch share by 26 points when found and 10 on July–September games (7 net of the league), same direction 78% (no tell: 0, 50%; Figure 1B).
- The 10 largest 2025 cues all kept direction in 2026, shrinking 44 to 29 points (Table 1).
- TELL’s within-season split-half reliability is 0.75; across seasons, $r = 0.22$ (count usage 0.62).
- Predictability is not associated with worse outcomes. From its 10th to 90th percentile, whiffs rise 1.1 points ($t = 6.8$) and pitchers save 0.26 more runs per 100 pitches ($t = 4.7$), also with the prior pitch’s result controlled.
- The alarm fired for 25% of 2025 pitchers (median 436 pitches), 1% of cue-free controls, and 1.6% of simulations where the count responds to each pitch (Figure 1C).
- In 2026, the first ABS-challenge season, the called zone’s top was 1.2 inches lower (2024→25: 0.2); TELL changed +0.01 millibits (95% CI -1.86 to $+1.88$; 2024→25: -0.49). The zone moved; sequencing did not.

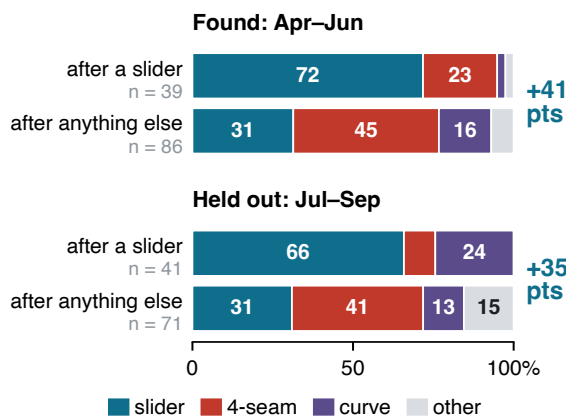
Conclusion. Sequencing tells are real but shrink by a third to two-thirds when held out, and overall predictability is far less stable across seasons than within one. Clubs should validate cues on held-out games, discount them, and track them with the alarm. Data and code: github.com/aidaneichman/the-tell.

Table 1. Top 2025 cues (50+ pitches; 25+ in 2026). Shift = share of the pitch after the cue minus after other previous pitches, same count and hand (points).

Pitcher	Situation	Next pitch	Found 2025	Held out 2026	n 2026
Dylan Lee	0-1 vs RHB, after slider	slider	+66	+44	62
Jack Leiter	1-2 vs LHB, after 4-seam	4-seam	-46	-17	39
Kevin Gausman	0-2 vs LHB, after 4-seam	4-seam	+45	+25	74
Chris Sale	0-1 vs RHB, after slider	4-seam	-44	-25	111
Gregory Soto	0-1 vs RHB, after sinker	sinker	+43	+22	48
Matthew Boyd	2-2 vs RHB, after change	4-seam	+41	+28	54
Hunter Brown	0-1 vs RHB, after sinker	sinker	+40	+36	50
Kris Bubic	1-0 vs RHB, after 4-seam	4-seam	+38	+43	36
Drew Rasmussen	1-2 vs LHB, after cutter	cutter	-38	-26	51
Dustin May	1-2 vs LHB, after sweeper	sweeper	-37	-23	31

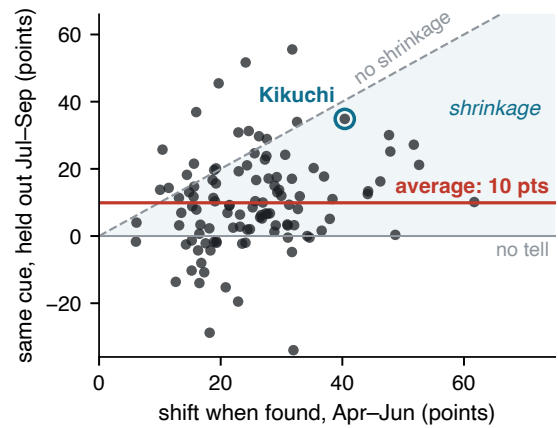
A One cue: Yusei Kikuchi, 2025, 1-0 count vs RHB

next-pitch mix after a slider vs after anything else



B Every pitcher's top cue, held out (n = 110)

found 26 pts, held out 10; same sign 78% (no tell: 0, 50%)



C An in-season alarm

permutes pitch order within count and batter hand, game by game

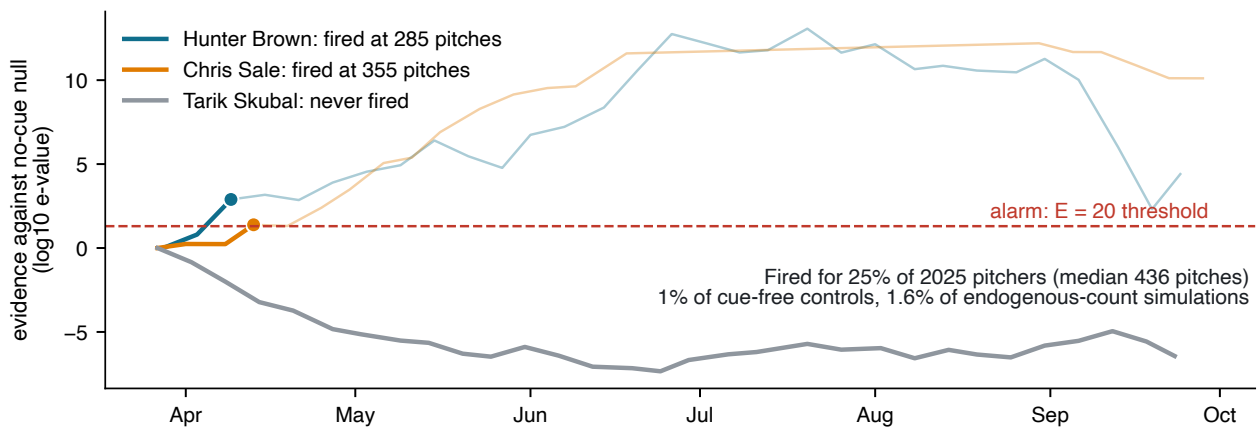


Figure 1. (A) Cue found Apr-Jun 2025, held out Jul-Sep. (B) Top Apr-Jun cues (30+ pitches each way), re-scored Jul-Sep (10+).